Home of the Brave

By Katherine Applegate

The night my cousin Ganwar lost his hand

Was the night I lost

my father and brother,

The night of men in the sky with guns,

The night the earth opened up like a black pit

And swallowed my old life whole.

INTRODUCTION

South Sudan has been devastated by decades of war in which 2 million people have died and 4 million have been forced to flee Today, UNICEF estimates that 17 percent of South Sudan's entire child population is without one or both parents. They have lost fathers, mothers, siblings -- everything dear to them. Kek was one of the more fortunate . . . he escaped the civil war to live with relatives in the United States – the land of the free and the . . .

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Are you glad that you're here, Ganwar?

I ask.

This is a good land, he says.

There's great freedom here.

But even when you travel far,

The ghosts don't stay behind.

They follow you.

You come here to make a new life,

But the old life is still haunting you.

We don't say anything for a few minutes.

Finally Ganwar speaks.

They're all gone, Kek.

They're all dead.

I want to hate Ganwar for his words.

But I am too weary for anger.

Already there are so many people to hate,

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Too many.

Not all, I finally whisper.
Not mama.

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A woman sits behind a pile of papers
Tall as a termite mound.

"We've been trying to get more information on your mom, Kek.
Here's what we've got."

My hope flutters high
Like a bird I cannot catch.
I ready my heart for the words I need to hear:
Found her. Good news. Coming here.
Those are the words she must say.

"This is a very difficult process,"

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she says.
"Refugees in that area move frequently,
And tracking someone down can be
Almost impossible."

"I don't want to get your hopes up, Kek.
We'll know more in a while."
That night,
I try on the school clothes
In the box they have brought for me.
I pick a button shirt with flowers on it
And soft red pants,
But Ganwar rolls his eyes.
Those are pajamas, he says.
You wear them when you sleep.

I try again.
Ganwar shakes his head.
The kids will eat you alive, he says.

This is bad news,

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Since I didn't know that America people
Like to eat each other.
Ganwar must see the fear in my eyes
Because he explains:
It means they'll beat you up.

Ganwar finds a pair of hard blue pants
And a shirt the color of sand.
Jeans, he says, T-shirt.

In the bathing room
I look hard in the shiny glass.
I wonder if I look
Like an America boy.

I'm not sure if that would be
A good thing or a not-good thing.

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They take me to school.

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When I see it, I use the words
I learned from the TV machine:
No way!
It's big enough to graze
A herd of cattle in,
Made of fine, red square stones
And surrounded by many
Tall not-dead trees.

This will be your desk.
Have a seat.
She points to a shiny chair
And a little table.

A chair of my own
And a table, too?

I'm very sorry, but I can't,
I say softly. I don't have the cattle
For such a fine desk as this.

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Oh, she says,
You don't have to pay for this desk, Kek.
School's free here.
You just bring your mind
And your smile
Every day, OK?

Carefully I sit.
I like very much this new desk.

My mouth will not stop smiling.

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It isn't hunger I feel today.
This pain is worse,
This pain is a question,
The one my heart will not stop asking:
Why am I here,
When so many others are not?
Why should I have a desk

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And a pair of fine jeans
And a soft place for my head to rest?
Why should I have the freedom to hope
While my brother and father
Sleep in bloodied earth?

I should not take these gifts
I do not deserve.
Listen, buddy, they say.
I'm afraid we've got some more news.
They tracked down the people who made it
To the two refugee camps we told you about.

None of them was your mom, Kek.

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I'm in our tent at the camp,
And all around me children and women sleep.
We are too crowded to lie down.
We sleep on each other, legs and arms twined.

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I'm not so hungry tonight.
Grain came in bags from the helping people today.
Mosquitoes buzz at the tent flaps,
Louder and louder still,
And then I know it is the drone of a flying boat.
The gunfire is almost gentle at first – pop—pop—pop,
And then it gets closer
And the world goes crazy with fear.

Children scream, mothers sob, men threaten.
A fire is burning somewhere close.
My mother takes my hand, firm, sure.
Come, my child, she says, as if we were
going for a walk to look at the moon.
We run from the tent
Pretending a safe place lies just a few steps away.
My mother falls, her dress caught on a bush,
And then the gunfire comes harder,
Flying toward us like hot little stars.
Run, Kek, my mother screams, run now.
I kneel beside her. I can't leave you, I say,

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Or I think I say, for my voice is swallowed by the roaring night.
My leg's hurt, I can't run. You hide in the trees.
You can get help for me when it's safe.
Go. Now.

And I run
And the trees are waiting
And the men come
With their knives and their guns and their mysterious hate.

I wait with other children.
I hold a little child and cover her mouth
When she tries to cry.
Dawn comes, silence comes,
Blood and death are everywhere.

And my mother is gone.

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I awake to no blood, no bodies,

No Mama.

I'm on the sofa, and Ganwar sits on the floor

Next to me.

You were moaning, he says.

It must have been a bad one.

I wipe my wet cheeks.

Very bad. I was in the camp,

And the men with guns came.

Ganwar nods. He clicks on a light

And the shadows take form.

I still have that one sometimes.

Not like this one. I shiver.

How can you be so sure, he asks.

You can't visit my head.

Because mine has truth in it, I say.

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Because in mine –

I drop my head in my hands –

Because in mine I leave Mama

And run.

In mine I'm a coward.

And it's the truth.

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I wait till Ganwar falls asleep.

I don't want to be here anymore.

I don't want to be in a place where

My words taste wrong in my mouth.

I don't want to live in a place where

Every year the trees must die.

I want to be in a place where the things

I love and know

Are there within my reach.

But where is that place?

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Fifteen months later –

The airplanes float in
One by one
But each one is the wrong one
And we wait
And wait
And wait some more.

At last the time comes
And the door opens
And people pour out
But no one is the right one.

One more person comes out,
Slow and searching.
A voice comes,
A voice like laughing water
On my thirsty heart:
My son!
And Mama embraces me

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I can't find words.
There are no words, not in my old language,
Not in my new one.
We walk together
Like one person,
Her arm tight around my shoulders,
And the air is wild with talking and
Laughter and questions,
So many questions,
But I don't speak.

I take a breath,
I take a step,
I hold out my hand.
She takes my hand
And at last
The right words come.

Mama, I say,
Welcome home.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Katherine Applegate
ISBN: 978-0312535636
Publisher: Square Fish
Date (Month/Year): December 2008

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